



### FULL SUPPORT

The salty seawater provides most of the nutrients that marine animals need. It also supports their bodies, so most do not need strong skeletons. This allows simple, soft-bodied, drifting creatures, such as this jellyfish, to flourish. On land, they would collapse, dry out, and die—as happens to jellyfish and even whales if they are washed ashore and stranded on beaches.



### HUNGRY SHOALS

Small zooplankton provide food for fish such as anchovies and herring, which filter them from water flowing through their gills. Shoals of fish attract hunters such as tuna, marlin, and sharks. This blacktip reef shark has terrified its prey into forming a tight, swirling bait ball as they all try to hide behind each other.

### FLOOR FEEDERS

Shallow seafloors are home to bottom-feeding fish such as cod and flatfish, various mollusks and anemones, spiny-skinned starfish and sea urchins, and crustaceans such as heavily armored crabs and lobsters. They feed on plankton, organic debris, and one another.



### GENTLE GIANTS

The zooplankton are also targeted by huge filter-feeding whales and giant fish such as the whale shark, the basking shark, and the manta ray (below). These animals devour immense quantities of tiny sea creatures every day. They grow this large partly because of the way that the water supports their bodies.

A manta ray's "wings" can measure 23 ft (7 m) from tip to tip.

